

WORKING PAPER

**Knowledge Management as Operational Infrastructure: Information Systems and
Organizational Capacity in Nonprofit Organizations**

Warren A. Jones, MBA

Working Paper

2025

ORCID: <https://orcid.org/0009-0002-9186-3970>

Author Note

Correspondence concerning this article should be addressed to the author.

Email: wjones@sparkproservices.com

Abstract

This paper examines knowledge management as a form of operational infrastructure in nonprofit organizations. Drawing on scholarship in knowledge management, information systems, organizational memory, and nonprofit management, it considers how organizations create, retain, organize, transfer, and apply the knowledge required to perform their work. The paper argues that nonprofit knowledge management should be understood less as a discrete technology or administrative function and more as an organizational capacity that connects people, processes, information systems, documentation, and institutional memory. This distinction is particularly important in nonprofit organizations, where resource constraints, staff turnover, reliance on volunteers, fragmented information systems, and informal work practices can make organizational knowledge unusually dependent on individuals. Under these conditions, the long-tenured employee who knows how a process actually works, the spreadsheet understood by one staff member, and the undocumented workaround used to satisfy a funder are not minor administrative peculiarities. They represent concentrations of operational knowledge and therefore sources of organizational risk. The literature suggests that technology can support knowledge management but cannot substitute for organizational practices that determine what knowledge is captured, where it resides, how it is transferred, and whether it is available when decisions are made. The paper concludes by identifying research opportunities concerning knowledge concentration, information-system fragmentation, organizational continuity, and the relationship between knowledge infrastructure and nonprofit capacity.

Keywords: *knowledge management, nonprofit organizations, information systems, organizational capacity, organizational memory, institutional knowledge, knowledge transfer*

Knowledge Management as Operational Infrastructure: Information Systems and Organizational Capacity in Nonprofit Organizations

Introduction

Most organizations have more knowledge than they have organized knowledge.

The distinction matters. Staff members know how programs operate, which funder requirements require special attention, why a reporting process developed in a particular way, which community partners can be called when something goes wrong, and where exceptions to formal procedures have accumulated over time. Some of this knowledge exists in policies, databases, shared drives, grant files, procedure manuals, and information systems. Much of it does not. It exists in individual memory, informal routines, email histories, personal spreadsheets, relationships, and practices that are understood by the people performing the work but have never been made fully visible to the organization.

Knowledge management is concerned with this organizational problem: how knowledge is created, captured, organized, transferred, retrieved, and applied. The field has a substantial scholarly history, including research on organizational learning, tacit and explicit knowledge, organizational memory, information systems, and knowledge transfer. Yet knowledge management is often discussed in ways that make it sound more specialized than the underlying problem actually is. In practice, almost every organization manages knowledge whether it has a formal knowledge-management program or not. The more consequential question is whether it manages that knowledge deliberately.

This distinction is especially important in nonprofit organizations. Nonprofits frequently operate under conditions that make informal knowledge valuable and its loss particularly

disruptive. Staffing structures can be lean. Administrative capacity may lag behind program growth. Funding requirements can produce specialized reporting processes that exist alongside ordinary operations. Volunteers and board members may hold consequential organizational knowledge despite participating intermittently. Technology investments are often accumulated incrementally rather than designed as integrated systems. A database may contain one set of information, the finance system another, individual departments may maintain their own spreadsheets, and staff may rely on email or personal memory to connect them.

Under those conditions, organizational continuity can depend heavily on people rather than systems. The employee who has been with an organization for 15 years may effectively function as a database. A program manager may maintain a spreadsheet that has become the unofficial source of truth because the formal system cannot produce the information staff actually need. A finance employee may know how to reconcile a grant because they remember decisions made several years earlier. A departing executive may take with them the history of why particular partnerships, policies, or operating practices exist.

These examples are often described as documentation problems. That is partly correct, but incomplete. Documentation is one component of a larger knowledge infrastructure. The underlying issue is whether an organization can retain and use what it has learned independently of the continued presence of particular individuals.

This paper synthesizes literature on knowledge management and considers its implications for nonprofit organizational capacity. It does not present original empirical findings. Instead, it examines how organizational knowledge is conceptualized, how information systems contribute to its management, why nonprofit operating conditions create distinctive knowledge vulnerabilities, and what effective knowledge infrastructure requires beyond technology. The

argument running through the paper is that knowledge management should be treated as operational infrastructure. It is not an administrative extra layered on top of mission work. It is part of the capacity through which mission work remains reliable, transferable, and sustainable.

A note on scope is useful. The knowledge-management literature is substantially broader than the nonprofit-management literature on the subject. This review therefore draws on foundational organizational and information-systems scholarship alongside studies conducted specifically in nonprofit settings. That imbalance is itself significant. Nonprofit organizations are knowledge-intensive institutions, but the consequences of how they manage operational knowledge remain less developed in nonprofit scholarship than subjects such as governance, fundraising, leadership, and financial capacity.

What Organizations Actually Know

One of the most useful contributions of knowledge-management scholarship is the recognition that organizational knowledge cannot be reduced to information stored in files.

Alavi and Leidner (2001) describe organizational knowledge as embedded across multiple locations, including individuals, routines, organizational culture, policies, systems, and documents. Their framework identifies four interrelated knowledge-management processes: knowledge creation, storage and retrieval, transfer, and application. The sequence is important. An organization gains relatively little simply by possessing information. Knowledge becomes organizationally useful when it can be located, interpreted, transferred to the people who need it, and applied to action.

This helps distinguish knowledge from data and information. A nonprofit may possess years of program data without having developed organizational knowledge from it. It may maintain thousands of documents without being able to retrieve the correct one. It may have

experienced staff members who know precisely why a program succeeds without having transferred that understanding beyond their immediate team. The existence of information and the organizational capacity to use it are different conditions.

The distinction between tacit and explicit knowledge further clarifies the problem. Nonaka (1994) describes organizational knowledge creation as an interaction between knowledge that can be articulated and knowledge that remains rooted in experience, judgment, and practice. Explicit knowledge can be formalized: procedures, reports, formulas, policies, instructions, templates, and records. Tacit knowledge is more difficult to capture because people often know more about performing their work than they can easily explain.

This is visible in ordinary nonprofit operations. A development officer may formally document how gifts are entered into a donor database but possess tacit knowledge about the history of major donor relationships. A grants manager may have a written reporting calendar but also know which funders routinely request additional information and which internal departments need repeated follow-up. An executive assistant may understand board procedures that are technically reflected in bylaws but operationally depend on years of experience with individual board members. A program director may know which performance indicators are useful for managing a program even though the organization's formal reporting requirements emphasize different measures.

The organizational challenge is not to convert every form of tacit knowledge into documentation. That would be unrealistic and, in many cases, undesirable. Judgment cannot be fully transformed into a manual. Relationships cannot be reduced to database fields. Experience remains valuable precisely because it enables people to interpret circumstances that formal procedures cannot anticipate.

The more realistic objective is to prevent critical organizational capacity from existing only as tacit knowledge.

That distinction matters because tacit knowledge becomes an organizational vulnerability when no mechanism exists for transferring it. Nonaka's (1994) model of organizational knowledge creation emphasizes interaction between tacit and explicit knowledge rather than the elimination of either. Organizations develop knowledge socially, articulate parts of what they know, combine that knowledge with other information, and internalize it through use. Knowledge management is therefore a continuous organizational process rather than an exercise in writing procedure manuals.

Hansen et al. (1999) describe a related strategic distinction between codification and personalization. Codification emphasizes making knowledge reusable through documents and information systems. Personalization emphasizes connecting people so that knowledge can move through direct interaction. Neither strategy is universally superior. Some knowledge is efficiently captured in a repository. Other knowledge is useful primarily when people can locate and consult someone with relevant expertise.

For nonprofit organizations, the practical implication is straightforward: a shared drive is not a knowledge-management strategy, and neither is relying on experienced employees to teach everyone else informally. Effective knowledge infrastructure requires both accessible organizational information and functioning pathways between people.

Organizational Memory and the Problem of Continuity

Knowledge management becomes particularly consequential when viewed through the concept of organizational memory.

Walsh and Ungson (1991) developed one of the field's foundational frameworks for understanding how organizations retain information from their histories. Organizational memory resides not in a single repository but across individuals, organizational culture, transformations and routines, structures, the physical environment, and external archives. Stein and Zwass (1995) subsequently examined the role of information systems in making organizational memory available for current organizational activity.

This framing makes organizational memory more than record retention. Archives preserve what happened. Organizational memory concerns whether knowledge from what happened can influence what an organization does now.

That difference is easy to miss. An organization may technically retain every grant report it has submitted during the past decade and still have poor organizational memory. If those reports are stored inconsistently, cannot be searched effectively, are separated from the underlying performance data, or are unknown to the staff preparing the next proposal, the information has been retained without becoming meaningfully accessible.

The same is true of organizational decisions. Meeting minutes may record that a board approved a policy without preserving the reasoning that produced it. A finance procedure may document what staff currently do without explaining the funder restriction or audit finding that caused the procedure to develop. A program may abandon an approach that failed, then attempt essentially the same strategy five years later because the staff members who understood the previous failure have left.

Organizational memory therefore affects continuity in at least two ways. First, it reduces the need for organizations to rediscover information they once possessed. Second, it preserves

context - the reasoning, relationships, exceptions, and prior experience that make information interpretable.

The second function is particularly important. Data without context can create the appearance of organizational knowledge while concealing its absence. A spreadsheet may contain a number but not explain how it was calculated. A dashboard may show declining performance but not record the programmatic change that produced the decline. A contract file may show an obligation without documenting the informal agreement that shaped how the partnership actually functioned.

Long-tenured employees often become the mechanism through which that context is preserved. They remember the old funding agreement, the previous database, the staff restructuring, the board decision, the community controversy, or the reason an apparently inefficient process exists. Their value to the organization extends beyond the tasks in their job descriptions. They become repositories of institutional context.

This can create a misleading form of organizational stability. A process may appear well established because it works consistently while a particular employee is present. Its underlying fragility becomes visible only when that person is absent, promoted, retires, or leaves the organization.

The resulting disruption is frequently interpreted as a personnel problem. In reality, it is also an infrastructure problem. If essential operating knowledge disappears when one employee does, the organization has concentrated a critical organizational asset in a single point of failure.

The Nonprofit Knowledge-Management Context

The limited literature focused specifically on nonprofit organizations suggests that these organizations face knowledge-management challenges that are shaped by their operating environments.

Lettieri et al. (2004), in an exploratory study of Italian nonprofits, argued that knowledge represents an especially important resource for organizations expected to deliver increasingly sophisticated services under persistent resource constraints. Their work positioned knowledge management as part of organizational effectiveness rather than merely an information-technology practice. Hume and Hume (2008) similarly examined knowledge management as a strategic capability in nonprofit organizations facing competition for funding, staff, volunteers, and public support.

These arguments remain relevant because nonprofit organizations often have unusually complex relationships between resources and outputs. Many produce services in which professional judgment, community knowledge, case histories, relationships, and institutional experience are integral to delivery. The organization's knowledge is therefore not peripheral to the service. In many organizations, it is part of the service.

At the same time, nonprofits may have fewer resources available to build the systems that preserve this knowledge. Mahasuar's (2023) study of nonprofit knowledge-management practices found organizations navigating competing institutional demands while developing KM practices in resource-constrained environments. The study identified bricolage and socialization among the ways nonprofits compensate for limited resources. That finding captures an important feature of nonprofit operations: organizations frequently make systems work by combining

available tools, informal practices, staff relationships, and local adaptations rather than through fully designed infrastructure.

Bricolage can be an organizational strength. Nonprofit employees regularly make effective use of limited resources, improvise solutions, and adapt systems to circumstances that were not anticipated when the systems were purchased. But the same capacity can obscure structural weakness. A process held together by skilled improvisation may work very well until the people who designed the workaround are no longer there.

Consider a nonprofit that uses a constituent relationship management system for some information, accounting software for financial transactions, a cloud drive for contracts and supporting documents, an email marketing platform for communications, and several spreadsheets for management reporting. None of these tools is necessarily inadequate. The operational problem exists in the spaces between them.

Who understands how a constituent moves from one system to another? Which system is authoritative when records conflict? Where is the historical explanation for changes in reporting definitions? Who maintains the spreadsheet that reconciles program activity with financial reporting? How does a new employee learn which fields cannot be trusted? Where is the distinction between a formal procedure and a workaround that became permanent?

These questions reveal why knowledge management and information-system management overlap but are not identical.

Rathi and Given's (2017) comparative study of nonprofits in Canada and Australia examined the technologies used for knowledge-management activities and demonstrated the variety of tools nonprofits employ to create, organize, and share knowledge. Technology expands what organizations can capture and distribute. Yet adding technology does not

automatically produce integrated organizational knowledge. An organization can have more platforms and simultaneously have less clarity about where authoritative information resides.

This is a common infrastructure problem. The unit of analysis should not be the individual software product. It should be the information environment through which work moves.

When Information Systems Become Organizational Infrastructure

Information systems are often evaluated functionally. Does the donor system process donations? Does the finance system produce financial statements? Does the case-management system record services? Does the document platform store files?

Knowledge infrastructure requires a broader question: do these systems collectively allow the organization to know what it needs to know?

Alavi and Leidner (2001) conceptualized knowledge-management systems as information-technology-based systems that support organizational processes of knowledge creation, storage and retrieval, transfer, and application. This definition is useful because it shifts attention away from technology as an object and toward technology as part of an organizational process.

A technically capable system can still fail as knowledge infrastructure.

Consider a database that contains accurate program information but can be queried by only one staff member. The information exists, but access is concentrated. Consider a shared drive with years of complete documentation organized according to a folder structure that reflects departments that no longer exist. The information has been preserved, but retrieval has degraded. Consider a dashboard that automatically refreshes from several data sources but uses

measures that managers do not trust. The information is available but does not reliably support decision-making.

These failures are not primarily technical. They sit at the intersection of system design, organizational practice, governance, and human behavior.

A knowledge infrastructure therefore requires several conditions simultaneously. Information must be captured. The organization must know where authoritative information resides. Staff must be able to retrieve it. Definitions must be sufficiently consistent that users interpret information similarly. Historical context must be preserved where it matters. Access must be broad enough to support work but controlled enough to protect sensitive information. And knowledge has to reach the point of decision.

The final condition is easily overlooked.

Organizations can become very good at producing information that does not meaningfully enter management. Reports are generated because funders require them. Dashboards exist because leadership requested them. Evaluations are completed and presented. Staff attend debriefs. Yet the knowledge produced through these activities may remain disconnected from resource allocation, strategy, program design, or operational decisions.

Knowledge application is therefore the point at which information infrastructure becomes organizational capacity.

A nonprofit that can retrieve five years of performance data has one capability. A nonprofit that can use those data, together with staff experience and community knowledge, to decide whether to redesign a program has another. The second depends on the first, but it cannot be reduced to it.

Documentation Is Necessary but Not Sufficient

Organizations experiencing knowledge loss often respond by calling for more documentation. The instinct is reasonable. Its limitations deserve attention.

Documentation is essential for making certain forms of organizational knowledge persistent. Standard operating procedures, process maps, data dictionaries, decision logs, board records, project histories, grant calendars, relationship records, and system documentation can substantially reduce dependence on individual memory.

But organizations can document themselves into another kind of failure.

A procedure manual that is never updated becomes misinformation. A shared drive containing multiple versions of the same policy forces users to decide which document is authoritative. A detailed process guide that no one can locate at the moment of need provides little operational value. Documentation created exclusively for compliance may describe the process that is supposed to occur rather than the process staff actually use.

The relevant measure is therefore not the volume of documentation. It is whether documentation reduces ambiguity and makes important knowledge usable.

This requires selectivity. Not everything needs to be captured with equal precision. The organization first has to identify which knowledge is operationally critical. What would create meaningful disruption if it disappeared tomorrow? Which processes are performed by only one person? Which reports depend on formulas nobody else understands? Which external relationships have no institutional owner beyond one employee? Which decisions repeatedly require staff to reconstruct historical context? Which systems contain information that cannot readily be extracted or interpreted?

These are knowledge-risk questions.

They also suggest that documentation should be treated as part of process design rather than as a project completed after the process already exists. When staff are expected to remember to document work separately, documentation competes with the work itself. When knowledge capture is built into workflows - through standardized fields, automated records, templates, decision logs, routine debriefs, or defined handoff procedures - the organization is more likely to preserve what it needs without creating unsustainable administrative burden.

The objective should not be to write down everything employees know. It should be to design work so that critical knowledge does not disappear invisibly.

Turnover, Handoffs, and Knowledge Concentration

Staff turnover is one of the clearest moments at which an organization's knowledge infrastructure is tested.

Most organizations have experienced some version of the rushed transition: an employee gives notice, colleagues begin asking for passwords and files, a list of open projects is assembled, and the departing employee spends their final days trying to explain months or years of accumulated work. The organization calls this knowledge transfer.

What actually occurs is often knowledge triage.

A meaningful transfer process begins before anyone resigns. It requires enough organizational visibility that managers already know which processes a role controls, which systems it uses, which external relationships depend on it, where work products are stored, and which knowledge is not yet shared.

The issue becomes more serious when knowledge concentration reflects organizational structure. Small nonprofits may have only one finance employee, one development professional, one database administrator, or one person managing a specialized grant portfolio. Larger

nonprofits are not immune. Departmental silos can reproduce the same condition at greater scale: multiple people may work in a function while only one understands a particular system, reporting process, partnership, or institutional history.

Knowledge concentration is not inherently bad. Expertise requires specialization. The risk emerges when the organization lacks redundancy around knowledge that is necessary for continuity.

This suggests a distinction between specialized expertise and single-person dependency. An organization may reasonably rely on a finance director's professional expertise. It should not have to rely on that finance director being the only person who knows where banking credentials are maintained, how a recurring report is generated, or why a major reconciliation contains a standing adjustment.

The same principle applies to executives. Executive transitions receive considerable attention in the nonprofit sector, yet succession planning is frequently conceptualized around identifying or developing the next leader. Knowledge continuity is a separate issue. An incoming executive may inherit the job without inheriting the organizational memory required to understand it.

Board transitions create similar challenges. Board members accumulate historical understanding about strategic decisions, executive performance, governance disputes, funder relationships, and organizational risk. Because board service is intentionally temporary, governance systems must transfer that knowledge across cohorts. Otherwise, rotation designed to strengthen accountability can inadvertently weaken institutional memory.

Volunteers introduce another dimension. Rybak (2023) emphasizes the importance of including volunteers in nonprofit knowledge-management systems. This is especially

consequential in organizations where volunteers perform substantial program, governance, fundraising, or community-facing work. Knowledge infrastructure that recognizes only paid employees misunderstands where organizational knowledge actually resides.

Knowledge Management and Organizational Capacity

The strongest case for treating knowledge management as infrastructure is its relationship to organizational capacity.

Capacity is often discussed in categories: financial capacity, human resources, technology, leadership, governance, evaluation, fundraising, or facilities. Knowledge management cuts across these categories because each depends on the organization's ability to retain and use information about its own operations.

Financial capacity depends partly on knowledge of restrictions, revenue assumptions, cost structures, and historical decisions. Human-resource capacity depends on the transfer of job knowledge, policies, expectations, and organizational culture. Governance depends on access to reliable information and institutional history. Evaluation depends on stable definitions, usable data, and the ability to preserve learning across program cycles. Strategy depends on an organization's ability to connect past experience, current information, and future choices.

Knowledge is therefore not simply another capacity domain. It is connective infrastructure among domains.

This is why weak knowledge management often presents as other problems. A reporting deadline is missed and appears to be a performance problem. The deeper issue is that the reporting process lived in one employee's calendar. A board receives inconsistent metrics and appears insufficiently engaged in oversight. The underlying issue is that departments define the same measures differently. Staff recreate an analysis performed two years earlier and the

problem appears to be inefficiency. The deeper issue is that the organization had no reliable way to retrieve prior work.

The costs are diffuse precisely because knowledge infrastructure is embedded in ordinary operations.

Organizations rarely have a budget line called "cost of not knowing what we already know." Instead, the cost appears as staff time spent searching, recreating, correcting, reconciling, asking, waiting, and recovering. It appears in slower onboarding. It appears when managers cannot answer basic questions without locating a particular employee. It appears when reports require heroic last-minute effort because the data needed for them were not structured correctly during the year. It appears when a departure causes months of disruption.

These are capacity losses.

They are also difficult to observe through conventional nonprofit performance measures. An organization may deliver all contracted services and close its fiscal year successfully while relying on highly fragile knowledge practices. Performance data show that the work occurred. They do not necessarily show how much hidden effort was required to make it occur or how dependent success was on particular individuals.

This distinction between visible performance and underlying capacity deserves greater research attention.

The Human Side of Knowledge Infrastructure

The infrastructure framing should not imply that the solution is primarily technical. Much of knowledge management depends on organizational culture and behavior.

People have to be willing to share what they know. They have to trust that documenting their work will not make them less valuable or expose them unfairly. Managers have to create

time for knowledge transfer. Teams have to develop habits of debriefing and reflection. Leaders have to reward practices that make work more transparent rather than allowing organizational indispensability to become a marker of professional worth.

This can be difficult because knowledge also carries power.

Employees who uniquely understand a system or relationship may derive informal authority from that expertise. Departments can protect information as a way of maintaining control. Leaders can restrict access because information has historically been treated as something distributed according to hierarchy rather than operational need. Some organizations become dependent on knowledge gatekeepers without intentionally creating that structure.

The result can be a paradox: the employees most valuable to organizational continuity are sometimes those whose knowledge has been least institutionalized.

A strong knowledge culture does not make expertise less valuable. It changes what the organization values about expertise. The strongest expert is not merely the person who can solve a problem nobody else can solve. It is also the person who builds the organization's capacity to solve that problem after they are gone.

Leadership matters here. If documentation, cross-training, data quality, debriefing, and knowledge transfer are treated as tasks employees should perform when they have extra time, they will predictably lose to immediate operational demands. Knowledge management becomes infrastructure only when leadership treats continuity and organizational learning as part of performance rather than as administrative housekeeping.

Questions That Remain

The general knowledge-management literature offers well-developed theories of organizational knowledge, memory, transfer, and information systems. The nonprofit literature

establishes that these questions operate differently under conditions of limited resources, multiple stakeholders, volunteer participation, and institutional complexity. What remains less developed is an organization-level understanding of how knowledge infrastructure affects nonprofit operating capacity in practice.

The first research opportunity concerns knowledge concentration. How dependent are nonprofit organizations on individual employees for operationally critical knowledge? The question could be examined at the process level rather than through general perceptions of documentation quality. Researchers might identify critical recurring processes - grant reporting, payroll, board administration, program evaluation, contract management, donor reporting - and assess how many individuals can independently perform them, where required information resides, and what happens when a primary knowledge holder is unavailable.

This would allow knowledge-management risk to be measured more concretely. An organization with extensive written procedures may still have high knowledge concentration if those procedures do not capture the context required to perform the work. Conversely, an organization with relatively light documentation may have strong continuity if teams routinely cross-train, systems are transparent, and expertise is distributed.

A second opportunity concerns information-system fragmentation. Nonprofit technology research often examines adoption of particular systems or categories of technology. The more operationally useful question may be how effectively information moves across the organization's entire system environment. How many systems contain overlapping records? Which are considered authoritative? How much staff labor is required to reconcile them? Where do spreadsheets or informal databases emerge to compensate for gaps in formal systems?

This last question is particularly interesting. The spreadsheet that only one person understands is easy to dismiss as bad practice. It may instead be diagnostic evidence. It often exists because an employee needed information the organization's formal systems could not provide. Understanding why shadow systems emerge could reveal gaps between formal technology infrastructure and actual information needs.

A third research opportunity concerns turnover and organizational continuity. Much nonprofit workforce research understandably examines recruitment, retention, compensation, burnout, and succession. Less attention is given to what organizations lose operationally when employees depart. Research could examine transition events longitudinally: what information becomes difficult to locate, which processes slow, where errors increase, and how long it takes the organization to restore prior levels of operating fluency.

A fourth concerns organizational memory and decision quality. Nonprofits regularly make recurring strategic decisions about programs, partnerships, funding opportunities, staffing structures, and service models. To what extent are those decisions informed by accessible records of prior decisions and their outcomes? Can organizations explain why a current process exists? Do boards understand the historical context behind policies they are asked to revise? What mechanisms preserve not only decisions but the reasoning behind them?

Finally, there is a broader question about knowledge infrastructure and organizational scale. As nonprofits grow, informal systems that worked effectively at smaller size often become increasingly fragile. Personal relationships can no longer connect every part of the organization. Senior staff cannot carry all relevant context. Spreadsheets reach practical limits. Departmental specialization increases. The organization reaches a point at which knowledge that once moved socially has to move structurally.

When that transition occurs, and how organizations manage it, deserves considerably more attention. Growth is normally measured through revenue, employees, programs, or geographic reach. But organizational scale is also an information problem. At some point, an organization becomes too complex to know itself informally.

Conclusion

Knowledge management can sound abstract because knowledge itself is difficult to see. The infrastructure becomes visible when it fails.

It is visible when an employee leaves and nobody can reproduce a report. When staff spend hours searching for a document they know exists. When two departments present different answers to the same question because they rely on different systems. When a new employee learns that the written procedure is not how the process actually works. When a board revisits an issue without knowing why an earlier board made the decision it did. When an organization discovers that an essential operational process has never existed anywhere except in someone's memory.

These are not isolated administrative inconveniences. They are expressions of organizational capacity.

The knowledge-management literature has long established that organizational knowledge resides across people, routines, documents, systems, and organizational memory and that information technology can support, but does not itself constitute, effective knowledge management. Research focused specifically on nonprofit organizations adds an important operating context: organizations facing persistent resource constraints often depend on bricolage, informal communication, interpersonal relationships, and creatively assembled technology environments to get the work done.

Those adaptations are frequently strengths. They are also places where organizational risk can accumulate unnoticed.

The practical implication is not that nonprofits need elaborate knowledge-management departments or expensive new technology. For many organizations, that would misunderstand the problem. The starting point is much simpler: determine what the organization must continue to know in order to operate, identify where that knowledge currently resides, examine how it moves, and reduce unnecessary dependence on any single person, file, system, or informal workaround.

This requires documentation, but not documentation alone. It requires usable information systems, but not technology alone. It requires experienced staff, but not dependence on individual memory. It requires organizational practices that connect people, processes, information, and history in ways that allow knowledge to survive transitions and reach decisions.

Knowledge management, understood this way, is operational infrastructure.

A nonprofit organization cannot perform its mission consistently if it cannot reliably retain and use what it has already learned. The question is therefore not whether knowledge management deserves room among an organization's administrative priorities. It is whether an organization can reasonably claim to possess durable capacity when the knowledge required to operate disappears whenever the people carrying it walk out the door.

References

- Alavi, M., & Leidner, D. E. (2001). Review: Knowledge management and knowledge management systems: Conceptual foundations and research issues. *MIS Quarterly*, 25(1), 107-136. <https://doi.org/10.2307/3250961>
- Davenport, T. H., De Long, D. W., & Beers, M. C. (1998). Successful knowledge management projects. *Sloan Management Review*, 39(2), 43-57.
- Hansen, M. T., Nohria, N., & Tierney, T. (1999). What's your strategy for managing knowledge? *Harvard Business Review*, 77(2), 106-116.
- Hume, C., & Hume, M. (2008). The strategic role of knowledge management in nonprofit organisations. *International Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing*, 13(2), 129-140. <https://doi.org/10.1002/nvsm.316>
- Lettieri, E., Borga, F., & Savoldelli, A. (2004). Knowledge management in non-profit organizations. *Journal of Knowledge Management*, 8(6), 16-30. <https://doi.org/10.1108/13673270410567602>
- Mahasuar, K. (2023). Knowledge management practices in non-profit organizations: An institutional logics approach. *Knowledge and Process Management*, 30(3), 267-277. <https://doi.org/10.1002/kpm.1739>
- Matzkin, D. S. (2008). Knowledge management in the Peruvian non-profit sector. *Journal of Knowledge Management*, 12(4), 147-159. <https://doi.org/10.1108/13673270810884318>
- Nonaka, I. (1994). A dynamic theory of organizational knowledge creation. *Organization Science*, 5(1), 14-37. <https://doi.org/10.1287/orsc.5.1.14>

Rathi, D., & Given, L. M. (2017). Non-profit organizations' use of tools and technologies for knowledge management: A comparative study. *Journal of Knowledge Management*, 21(4), 718-740. <https://doi.org/10.1108/JKM-06-2016-0229>

Rybak, A. (2023). Managing knowledge in non-profit organisations. *Proceedings of the 24th European Conference on Knowledge Management*, 24(2), 1155-1164. <https://doi.org/10.34190/eckm.24.2.1528>

Stein, E. W., & Zwass, V. (1995). Actualizing organizational memory with information systems. *Information Systems Research*, 6(2), 85-117. <https://doi.org/10.1287/isre.6.2.85>

Walsh, J. P., & Ungson, G. R. (1991). Organizational memory. *Academy of Management Review*, 16(1), 57-91. <https://doi.org/10.5465/amr.1991.4278992>